
The Caregiver's Body

Companion Workbook — find permission and
practice that fits your actual life

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

The Caregiver's Body

Companion Workbook — find permission
and practice that fits your actual life

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

HEALING HANDS BY NATE

The Caregiver's Body

© 2026 Healing Hands By Nate. All rights reserved.

Nate Ratcliff, LMT

Inner Circle Deep Cut — #12 Workbook

For Healing Hands By Nate Inner Circle members. Personal use only. Please don't redistribute — share the membership instead.

Published by Healing Hands By Nate

Contents

1. How to use this workbook
2. Caregiver Self-Assessment
3. Reflection Prompts
4. Permission Practice
5. Micro-Practice Menu
6. My Caregiver Daily Practice Plan
7. 30-Day Caregiver Tracker
8. Support Resources
9. Quarterly Check-Ins
10. When Caregiving Ends — Recovery Plan
11. Try this for 30 days

Introduction

A YEAR-LONG COMPANION TO THE IC12 DEEP cut. Find permission and practice that fits your actual life.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

YEAR-LONG REFERENCE. SELF-ASSESSMENT first. Micro-practice menu to choose from based on available windows. Quarterly check-ins.

Bring it to every session.

CHAPTER 2

Caregiver Self-Assessment

Current caregiving role

I AM CURRENTLY CARING FOR:

- ☐ Young children (ages: ____)
- ☐ Aging parent(s)
- ☐ Disabled family member
- ☐ Patients (healthcare role)
- ☐ Multiple of above
- ☐ Recently ended caregiving role
- ☐ Not currently caregiving but recently was

Years in this caregiving role: ____

Hours per day of active caregiving: ____

Backup/relief support:

- ☐ Significant (multiple times per week)
- ☐ Some (once a week or so)
- ☐ Minimal (rare breaks)
- ☐ None

Physical assessment

Pain levels (0-10):

- Low back: [____]
- Neck/shoulders: [____]
- Hands/wrists: [____]
- Hips: [____]
- Headaches: [____]

Asymmetric tightness: [☐] Yes (which side: ____) / [☐]
No / [☐] Don't know

Sleep average: ____ hours

Self-care in past month:

- Bodywork: ____ sessions
- Exercise: ____ sessions
- Stretching: ____ days
- Time alone (>1 hour for myself): ____ days

Emotional/mental assessment

Sense of overwhelm (1-10): [____]

Sense of meaning in caregiving (1-10): [____]

Time for things that aren't caregiving (1-10):
[____]

Mental energy at end of day (1-10): [____]

Pattern identification

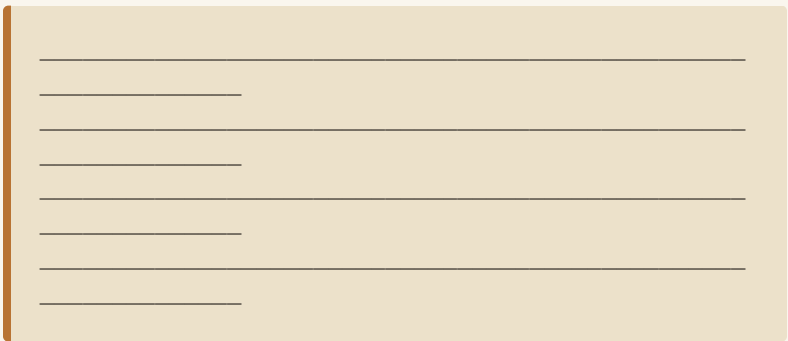
Which pattern from IC12 most matches my current situation:

- ☐ Depleted caregiver
 - ☐ “I’ll deal with it later” caregiver
 - ☐ Hidden injury caregiver
 - ☐ Reactive caregiver
 - ☐ Grateful caregiver
 - ☐ Post-caregiver
 - ☐ Combination
-

CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: WHEN WAS THE LAST TIME YOU DID something genuinely just for yourself? What was it? What does it tell you about your current patterns?

A rectangular box with a light beige background and a thin brown vertical line on the left side. Inside the box are eight horizontal lines for writing, spaced evenly.

Prompt 2: What story do you tell yourself about why self-care isn't possible right now? Write the story. Then question whether it's actually accurate, or whether it's a pattern.

The story I tell myself:

Is it accurate? What's a more nuanced version?

Prompt 3: If you knew your body would collapse in 2 years from accumulated caregiving load, what would you change starting today? Why aren't you doing those things now?

CHAPTER 4

Permission Practice

SOME AFFIRMATIONS TO READ REGULARLY:

- [] My body matters too
- [] Caring for myself is caring for them
- [] A collapsed caregiver helps no one
- [] Brief care is real care
- [] I model self-respect by practicing it
- [] The people I care for need me sustainable, not perfect

Write your own in your voice:

CHAPTER 5

Micro-Practice Menu

CHOOSE PRACTICES BASED ON THE TIME YOU ACTUALLY have, not the time you wish you had.

60-second practices (can fit in almost anywhere)

- [] Doorframe stretch (30 sec each direction)
- [] 10 slow breaths (diaphragmatic)
- [] Standing forward fold hang (30 sec)
- [] 10 shoulder rolls each direction
- [] 5 slow neck rotations each direction
- [] Wall pec stretch (30 sec each side)
- [] Cross-body shoulder stretch (30 sec each side)
- [] Quick body scan (notice tension, breathe into it)

When in my day can I do these?

5-minute practices (when child naps, brief quiet)

- [] Legs up the wall
- [] Cat-cow + thoracic mobility
- [] 5 minutes of focused breathing
- [] Hip flexor stretch + couch stretch
- [] Open-book stretch sequence
- [] Self-massage on one tight area
- [] Brief mindfulness practice

My typical 5-minute windows:

15-minute practices (when you can find a window)

- [] Full mobility routine (10-15 min from monthly modules)
- [] Walk outside
- [] Bodyweight workout (squats, push-ups, plank)
- [] Hot shower with focus on tight areas
- [] Full pre-bed wind-down sequence (from Bonus 3)

My typical 15-minute windows:

Practices to stack with caregiving tasks

- [] Stretch while watching kids play
- [] Calf raises while holding baby
- [] Walk briskly while pushing stroller
- [] Shoulder rolls during bath time
- [] Diaphragmatic breathing during feedings
- [] Body scan during routine tasks

Tasks I can stack with:

CHAPTER 6

My Caregiver Daily Practice Plan

DESIGNED FOR SUSTAINABILITY WITHIN ACTUAL life, not idealized self-care.

Morning micro-practice (60 sec): _____

Mid-day micro-practice (60 sec): _____

Evening micro-practice (60 sec): _____

Daily 5-minute practice (when window appears): _____

Weekly 15-minute practice goal: _____ sessions per week

Monthly bodywork goal: _____ sessions per month (if budget allows)

One non-negotiable practice: _____

CHAPTER 7

30-Day Caregiver Tracker

SIMPLER THAN OTHER TRACKERS — CAREGIVERS have less capacity for detailed tracking.

The Caregiver's Body

DAY	DATE	MI-CRO-PRAC-TICES DONE?	5-MIN WIN-DOW USED?	PAIN (0-10)	ONE WORD
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					
16					

DAY	DATE	MI-CRO-PRAC-TICES DONE?	5-MIN WIN-DOW USED?	PAIN (0-10)	ONE WORD
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					
25					
26					
27					
28					
29					
30					

CHAPTER 8

Support Resources

Resources to consider

FOR RESPITE CARE: - LOCAL SENIOR SERVICES / area agencies on aging (for elder care) - Religious organizations (often have volunteer support) - Family rotation (explicit asking) - Paid respite care services - Adult day programs (for elder/disabled care)

For mental health: - Therapist (especially caregiver-specialized) - Caregivers' support groups (in-person or online) - 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline if needed - Family doctor for evaluation

For my specific caregiving: - ☐ Specialist for the condition: __ - ☐ **Support group for this specific role:** __ - ☐ Educational resources: ____

Resources I've used:

Resources I should look into:

CHAPTER 9

Quarterly Check-Ins

Q1 Check-In — Date: ____

CAREGIVING ROLE: ☐ SAME / ☐ INCREASED / ☐
Decreased / ☐ Ended

Self-care practice consistency: ☐ Better / ☐
Same / ☐ Worse than 90 days ago

Pain levels: ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

Sense of overwhelm: ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐
Worse

Adjustments for next quarter:

Q2-Q4 Check-Ins

Continue same format quarterly.

CHAPTER 10

When Caregiving Ends — Recovery Plan

FOR THE EVENTUAL ENDING OF THIS CAREGIVING role (if applicable):

My anticipated end of this caregiving role:

My plan for the transition period:

Body recovery practices I'll prioritize:

Support I'll engage:

Identity recalibration approach:

CHAPTER 11

Try this for 30 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Doorframe stretch every time you walk through a doorway. For 30 days.

That's the practice. No dedicated time. Just every time you go through a door — 30 seconds of doorframe stretch.

If you walk through doorways 10 times a day, that's 5 minutes of cumulative chest/shoulder work without adding ANY time to your day.

After 30 days, most caregivers see noticeable reduction in upper-body tension.

If this works — build from there. If it doesn't — at least you tried something that didn't require finding time you don't have.

Bring this workbook to your next session. You deserve someone paying attention to your body.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
LMT and published by Healing Hands By
Nate.